Impression weighted memory design

Part 4 Sequence contrast and reinterpretation
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24 October 2026

This follow-up proposes a layer that preserves what happened, how it was first interpreted, and how its meaning changes with context. Sequence, contrast words and the receiver's priorities should remain separate inputs. The central design aim is to update interpretation without rewriting the original event or pretending the later interpretation was always present.

The order of an encounter can matter

The discussion began with felt value: how positive and negative encounters might shape what follows. Either pleasure or pain can come first. The working hypothesis is that a preceding experience can provide a reference point for interpreting a later one, with effects depending on the person and context. It does not establish that pain is necessary for pleasure, or that a first event determines someone's personality.

For memory design, preserve encounter order alongside the content. A sequence and a collection of the same events are not interchangeable descriptions. Whether order changes a particular judgment, and in which direction, remains a question to test rather than a universal rule.

Keep order separate from the connector

Consider four versions using the same two judgments:

- I like your shirt, and I dislike your pants.
- I dislike your pants, and I like your shirt.
- I like your shirt, but I dislike your pants.
- I dislike your pants, but I like your shirt.

Reversing the clauses tests order; replacing and with but tests the connector. Changing both at once would make their contributions hard to distinguish. Voice, pauses and delivery can add another influence, so they should be held constant in an initial comparison.

But adds a contrast to the claims

In ordinary contrastive uses, "A but B" typically asserts A and B while signaling a contrast or challenged expectation. The extra contribution is not a new Boolean truth value, nor does but simply mean an if-condition. Its precise linguistic analysis is debated. Research on but also shows that argument content can outweigh the expected connective-driven conclusion. [1]

A proposed BUT layer could therefore retain both claims, their order and the contrast being suggested. It should not erase A, turn B into its negation, or automatically declare that B matters most to every receiver.

The receiver has priorities too

Rick's addition is "the eye of the beholder": does this receiver care more about the pants or the shirt? A cherished shirt may make praise especially significant. Syntactic emphasis, intended contrast and personal significance are distinct inputs.

Additional information can change that weighting. A listener may reinterpret ordinary fashion criticism after learning that the shirt was a cherished gift. This hypothetical revision need not be kinder, more negative or more accurate.

Preserve an interpretation history

Store the event's source, timestamp, wording and delivery context. Link its initial interpretation to the evidence then available, the receiver's stated priorities and any uncertainty. Distinguish reported feelings from feelings inferred by an observer or model.

When information arrives, append a linked interpretation with its own time, evidence, context and reason for revision. Preserve the earlier version: meaning now is not necessarily meaning then. Later interpretations can also be mistaken; the newest is not automatically correct.

Proposed design operations

BUT(A, B, context) records the two claims and the suggested contrast or violated expectation. It supplies structure for interpretation, not a compulsory emotional ranking.

INTERPRET(event, context, time) records a perspective at a particular time. The context includes the receiver, priorities and available evidence; the result should distinguish explicit statements from inference.

REINTERPRET(prior interpretation, new context, time) appends a reasoned revision linked to its predecessor and the unchanged source event. These are proposed design labels, not standard programming built-ins or evidence of consciousness.

A small safe comparison

Use fictional vignettes with consenting participants, not surprise insults to unaware people. Compare the four sentence versions while controlling delivery and delay. Record the receiver's priorities, immediate interpretation and later interpretation after the same additional context. Counterbalance presentation order and compare connector effects separately from clause order and personal significance.

Test whether separating these variables explains differences better than a single positive or negative score. This note offers no empirical results or novelty claim. It proposes a history that records meaning then, meaning now and the reason for change.

Linguistic reference

[1] Leen Janssens and Walter Schaeken (2016). "But" Implicatures: A Study of the Effect of Working Memory and Argument Characteristics. Frontiers in Psychology 7:1520. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2016.01520